FARAH AKHTAR

BBA | MBA | PhD (Economics) - Quantitative Researcher & Higher Education Professional

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LinkedIn: https://www.linkedin.com/in/farah-akhtar-ph-d-1b116936/ | Google Scholar: https://scholar.google.com/citations?user=clqoToMAAAAJ&hl=en | ORCID: https://orcid.org/0009-0002-9436-4413

Quantitative researcher and higher-education administration professional with a PhD in Economics (Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman; viva successfully defended) specializing in structural equation modeling and ESG/digital-transformation research on SME financial performance. Author of four peer-reviewed publications and recipient of a Best Paper Award (BAFE 2024). Combines advanced statistical modeling (SmartPLS, SPSS, STATA) with five years of academic administration and thesis-defense coordination experience.

EDUCATION

PhD in Economics | 2023 - 2026

Universiti Tunku Abdul Rahman (UTAR), Kampar, Perak, Malaysia

- Thesis: "Unlocking Growth and Sustainability: The Impact of Digital Transformation and ESG on Financial Performance." Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Abdelhak Senadjki (Main); Dr. Vikniswari a/p Vijakumaran (Co-Supervisor).
- Best Paper Award - 12th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2024).

Master of Business Administration (MBA) | 2016 - 2018 | Merit - Chancellor's Honor Roll (CGPA > 3.5)

SZABIST (Shaheed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto Institute of Science and Technology), Pakistan

Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) | 2011 - 2015 | First-Class Honours

SZABIST (Shaheed Zulfikar Ali Bhutto Institute of Science and Technology), Pakistan

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Vija Kumaran, V. (2025). *Sustainability meets digital culture: the influence of ESG on financial performance in Malaysian manufacturing SMEs.* Journal of Innovative Digital Transformation, 2(1), 90-108. https://doi.org/10.1108/JIDT-10-2024-0031

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V. V. (2023). *Unearthing the Nexus between ESG and Financial Performance: Does Company Size and Age Matter?* In 11th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2023) (pp. 410-435). Atlantis Press. https://doi.org/10.2991/978-94-6463-342-9_30

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V. V. (2025). *Mapping the Underlying Factors of Firms' Economic Performance: Antecedents of Digital Transformation and ESG Reporting.* Malaysian Journal of Social Sciences and Humanities (MJSSH), 10(10), e003642. https://doi.org/10.47405/mjssh.v10i10.3642

Akhtar, F., Senadjki, A., & Kumaran, V. V. (2025). *Navigating the Digital Era: Role of Intellectual Capital in Enhancing the Financial Performance.* In Proceedings of the 12th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2024) (p. 21). Springer Nature. https://doi.org/10.2991/978-94-6463-666-6_3

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Academics & Records Officer | SZABIST, Larkana, Pakistan | *Aug 2017 - Apr 2022*

- Coordinated semester schedules and Academic Calendars; administered institutional academic data and reporting via ZABDESK.
- Organized Thesis and Dissertation Defense sessions and managed manuscript dispatch to evaluators, ensuring full procedural compliance.
- Conducted semester-wise structured teacher evaluations and presented findings to the Head of Campus.
- Maintained Faculty Digital Attendance Registers across BBA, MBA, and BSCS programs; supplied monthly financial data to Finance for faculty payments.
- Coordinated course registration and student enrolment workflows each semester.

Personal Banking Officer (O.G IV) | Summit Bank Limited, Sales & Liabilities Dept. | *Apr 2016 - Aug 2017*

- Managed end-to-end account opening/closing in compliance with bank policy and regulatory standards.
- Built trust-based customer relationships and identified cross-selling opportunities, contributing to branch customer-base growth.

Internships: Pakistan International Airlines, HR Services Dept. (Summer 2015) | Askari Commercial Bank, Larkana, Accounts & Problem Resolution Dept. (Summer 2013)

GRANTS, AWARDS & RECOGNITION

- Best Paper Award - "Navigating the Digital Era: Role of Intellectual Capital in Enhancing Financial Performance," 12th International Conference on Business, Accounting, Finance and Economics (BAFE 2024), 23 Oct 2024.
- UTAR Research Scholar Scheme - RM2,800/month, 01 Feb 2023 - 31 Jan 2026.
- Chancellor's Honor Roll - Outstanding Academic Performance, MBA Program, 01 Mar 2019.

TECHNICAL & RESEARCH SKILLS

SEM & Statistics: SmartPLS 4 (PLS-SEM, IPMA, PLSpredict), AMOS 28 (CB-SEM), R (lavaan, semTools), SPSS v29, STATA 17, EViews

Qualitative Tools: NVivo 14, ATLAS.ti

Data & Reporting: Microsoft Power BI, Tableau, Excel (Advanced: Pivot Tables, Power Query), SQL (PostgreSQL)

Research Tools: LaTeX, EndNote 21, Mendeley, Scopus, ZABDESK

Languages: English & Urdu (Proficient), Sindhi (Native), Punjabi (Conversational)

SELECTED PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

- Covariance-Based Structural Equation Modeling Using SmartPLS 4 - Bahcesehir Cyprus University (Prof. James Gaskin), Jan 2024.
- Researcher Academy: Scopus Platform Training - UTAR, Aug 2024.
- Excellence in Peer Review - Taylor & Francis Group, Nov 2024.
- Avoiding Predatory Publishing: Choosing Quality Journals - Taylor & Francis Group, May 2025.
- Open Access Publishing Success: A Guide for Authors - Wiley Customer Education, Nov 2025.
- Publishing Ethics 101 - Taylor & Francis Group, Apr 2015.

References available upon request